

INTRODUCTION

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The annual Medieval English Theatre meeting for 1999 was held in Edinburgh, with the topic under discussion being 'Play in Scotland'. Visitors with no more idea of what to expect from the city than Dunbar's lament that 'quhar gold and silk / Sold be, thair is bot crudis and milk' were in for a pleasant surprise. The conference, hosted by the University of Edinburgh, was set in the stunning surroundings of Pollock Halls, which nestle under Arthur's Seat and are close to Holyrood Palace. In appropriately medieval fashion, the proceedings began on the eve of the occasion, with a dinner to celebrate the twenty-first Medieval English Theatre meeting. A cake was cut, speeches were given, and the cross-section of ages and nationalities present testified to the continuing vitality of the group and its journal. As to the conference itself, John McGavin (who else?) got events underway with an introduction to play in Scotland, suggesting an admirable working definition for the day: to play is 'to display oneself metamorphosed'. Subsequent papers addressed this theme in relation to particular aspects of Scotland's literary and dramatic culture, from Peebles to Paris, and from the Abbot of Unreason to Mary, Queen of Scots. The speakers included Eila Williamson, Theo van Heijnsbergen, Jamie Reid Baxter, Keely Fisher, Sarah Carpenter, and Graham Runnalls. John Cartwright turned the tables on the visitors and presented a Scot's eye-view of an Antwerp *Ommegang*, giving the meeting plenty of puzzling observations to decipher.

If play is defined as the act of displaying oneself metamorphosed, then a useful means of classifying play is according to what one transforms oneself into. Unsurprisingly perhaps, people have always pushed at the limits of what they can become, and what they can shape words and images into. As *METH 20* records, 'the world upside-down', that catch-all category of everything unruly and outrageous, was the theme of the 1998 Medieval English Theatre meeting at the University of York. The present volume takes up this highly suggestive topic and interprets it in its broadest possible sense, taking in a range of dramatic, literary, and bodily metamorphoses which include subjects like deception and parody as well as the usual suspects like misrule and charivari. Overall, the aim is to explore the diversity of ways that tropes of reversal and inversion were used in medieval

drama and performance, underlining the contribution of this important but often neglected aesthetic category.

The papers in this volume therefore address a range of concerns. The practicalities of staging illusions and deceptions that work through the manipulation of sound, and the audience's willing complicity in such deceptions, are explored for medieval and later theatre (Butterworth). Another paper considers the theme of the world upside-down in relation to the language and performance of English mystery and morality plays (Hardwick). Three further papers consider those genres of performance whose very premise is a sense of inversion, namely festive misrule, farce, and charivari; in each case the aim is to improve our understanding and interpretation of the genre (Humphrey, Kramer, and Pettitt). There are also two editions of texts whose authors were obviously highly skilled practitioners of verbal and imaginative manipulation. Leif Søndergaard and Tom Pettitt offer an English translation of the sixteenth-century Danish play *The Unfaithful Wife*, in which a wife fights off a series of amorous advances from the three Estates of society. That is, until she is faced with the alarming prospect of being transformed into a weeping dog, at which point she has no choice but to satisfy her wooer's passion, 'rather than end in this canine fashion'. There is also an English version of a literary genre in which the right way up is difficult to discern, the mock-proclamation, and in this case its satirical thrust is only enhanced by 1999's experiences of eclipsical excitement and millennial fever (Jones). The papers by Paul Hardwick and myself were originally given at the 1998 Medieval English Theatre conference, whilst Femke Kramer's paper was presented to the triennial SITM colloquium at the University of Odense in August 1998.

Finally, given that this is *METH*'s birthday issue, we have also included a puzzle to entertain our readers: who is the enigmatic author of the letter which describes the delightful but as yet undiscovered *Pley of Controversie*? I would like to record two items of thanks: to Lyn Hitch for her generous help in typing, editing, and collating the papers, and to the editorial board of the journal, for inviting me to edit this volume.

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